

Napster

Shawn Fanning was motivated to write a program to aid finding and downloading music files because the existing methods were not satisfactory. The reasoning behind the project was that files that exist on one user's PC could be of interest to another user. Shawn's program combined Windows' file sharing program with IRC's chat capability and incorporated a search engine. The name refers to a nickname that Shawn was called by when in school. Convinced there would be a lot of demand for this service, Shawn's uncle helped him incorporate the venture, and they were also able to attract investors.

Though the files per se were stored on users PCs, the servers at napster.com tracked the details of the files (millions of them) that were being shared. The explosive spread of the service's users made Shawn famous (he was even interviewed by Time Magazine), though this also (naturally) attracted the attention of the Recording Industry Artists Association (RIAA), the body representing musicians and record labels. End-99, accusing Napster of encouraging piracy, RIAA filed a lawsuit requiring Napster to remove, from its servers, users sharing copyrighted music. The first lawsuit failed, and all the media attention further fuelled Napster's fame and contributed to an exponential increase in its users in the final months before the service was stopped. About 60 million users were reported to have used Napster in its heyday.

Napster made the Peer to Peer mode of file sharing popular, and spawned many other such networks, including Gnutella (which was launched in the year 2000 with the support of the maker of the popular media player Winamp, Nullsoft, though it withdrew support to the development quickly after), BearShare, Morpheus, etc. These clients were different from the Napster type of P2P—they did away with a central server, making it much more difficult to completely close down a service.

Napster was eventually forced to stop operations in 2001 by another court ruling and was eventually liquidated in 2002. In the liquidation auction, Roxio (makers of a popular media editing and playing software) was the buyer. Napster was re-launched as a paid service, but by that time, there were many players in the field—like iTunes.